

What we lose when AI does our shopping

Americans spend a remarkable amount of time shopping—more than on education, volunteering or even talking on the phone. But the way they shop is shifting dramatically, as major platforms and retailers race to automate commercial decision-making.

Artificial intelligence agents can already search for products, recommend options and even complete purchases on a consumer's behalf. Yet many shoppers remain uneasy about handing over control. Although many consumers report using some AI assistance, most currently say they wouldn't want an AI agent to autonomously complete a shopping transaction, according to a recent survey from the consultancy firm Bain & Company.

As scholars studying the intersection of law and technology, we have watched AI-assisted commerce expand rapidly. Our research finds that without updated legal measures, this shift toward automated commerce could quietly erode the economic, psychological and social benefits that people receive from shopping on their own terms.

Caveat emptor

Part of shoppers' hesitation is about privacy. Many are unwilling to share sensitive personal or financial information with AI platforms. But more profoundly, people want to feel in control of their shopping choices. When users can't understand the reasoning behind AI-driven product recommendations, their trust and satisfaction decline.



Shoppers are also reluctant to give away their autonomy. In one study involving people booking travel plans, participants deliberately chose trip options that were misaligned with their stated preferences once they were told their choices could be predicted — a way of reasserting independence.

Other experiments confirm that the more customers perceive their shopping choices being taken away from them, the more reluctant they are to accept AI purchasing assistance.

Although the technology is expected to get better, there have been some well-publicized missteps reported in financial and tech media. The Wall Street Journal wrote about an AI-powered vending machine that lost money and stocked itself with a live fish. The tech publication Wired cataloged design flaws, like an AI agent taking a full 45 seconds to add eggs to a customer's shopping cart.

The business case for AI shopping

Consumers have good reason to be cautious. AI agents aren't just designed to assist; they're designed to influence. Research shows that these systems can shape preferences, steer choices, increase spending and even reduce the likelihood that consumers return products.

And companies are hyping these capabilities. The business platform Salesforce promotes AI agents that can "effortlessly upsell," while payments giant Mastercard reports that its AI assistant, Shopping Muse, generates 15% to 20% higher conversion rates than traditional search — that is, pushing shoppers from browsing to completing a purchase.

For companies, the appeal is obvious. From Amazon's Rufus app and Walmart's customer support to AI-enabled grocery carts, companies are rapidly integrating these tools into the shopping experience.

Assistants with names like Sparky and Ralph are being promoted as the future of retail, while technologists are calling on companies to prepare their brands for the era of agentic AI shopping.

The real concern is not that these systems might fail, but that they may succeed all too well.

The human side to shopping

AI shopping agents do offer considerable benefits.

For example, they can scan numerous products in seconds, compare prices across sellers, track discounts over time, sift through thousands of product reviews, and tailor

recommendations to the user's preferences and needs. They can even read through terms of service and privacy policies, helping consumers detect unfavorable fine print.

But there's more at stake than these considerations.

While consumers have reason to focus on privacy and control, AI shopping agents carry some overlooked emotional risks, such as squashing the joy of anticipation. Psychologists have shown that the period between choosing a purchase and receiving it generates substantial happiness — sometimes more than the product or experience itself. We daydream about the vacation we booked, the outfit we ordered, the meal we planned. Automated buying threatens to drain this anticipatory pleasure.

This anticipation connects to another value: a sense of personal and ethical authorship. Even mundane shopping decisions allow people to exercise choice and express judgment. Many consumers deliberately buy fair-trade coffee, cruelty-free cosmetics or environmentally responsible products. The brands and products we choose, from Patagonia and Harley-Davidson to a Taylor Swift tour shirt, help shape who we are.

Shopping, moreover, has a communal dimension. We browse stores with friends, chat with salespeople and shop for the people we love. These everyday interactions contribute considerably to our well-being.

The same is true of gift-giving. Choosing a gift involves anticipating another person's preferences, investing effort in the search and recognizing that the gesture matters as much as the object itself. When this process is outsourced to an autonomous system, the gift risks becoming a delivery rather than a meaningful gesture of attention and care.

Keeping human agency alive

AI shopping agents are likely to become part of everyday life, and the regulatory conversation is beginning to catch up, albeit unevenly.

Transparency has emerged as a central concern. Past experience with recommendation engines shows that undisclosed conflicts of interest are a real risk. The European Union has proposed a disclosure framework around automated decision-making, although its implementation was recently delayed. In Congress,

U.S. lawmakers are considering bills to require companies to reveal how their AI models were trained.

So far, consumers seem to want to choose their own level of engagement — a signal that shopping, for many people, is more than just the efficient satisfaction of preferences. Perhaps the least-settled, yet most crucial question is whether AI shopping tools will be designed and regulated to serve users' interests and human flourishing — or optimized, as so many digital tools before them, primarily for corporate profit.

一、实战自测

1. According to the text, consumers are reluctant to rely fully on AI shopping agents mainly because they fear that AI may _____.

- [A] increase product prices dramatically
- [B] eliminate physical retail stores
- [C] take away their decision-making autonomy
- [D] fail to process transactions correctly

2. The author mentions gift-giving mainly to show that shopping also involves _____.

- [A] emotional and interpersonal value
- [B] financial responsibility
- [C] cultural misunderstanding
- [D] technological inefficiency

3. The author's attitude toward AI shopping agents is best described as _____.

- [A] blindly optimistic
- [B] cautiously concerned
- [C] completely dismissive
- [D] strongly supportive

4. Which of the following would be the best title for the text?

- [A] Why AI Shopping Will Completely Replace Human Consumers
- [B] The Hidden Human Cost of AI-Assisted Shopping
- [C] A Technological Revolution in Online Retail
- [D] How Companies Profit from Consumer Anxiety

参考答案与解析

1. C

解析：根据文章第四段和第五段，消费者不愿完全依赖 AI 购物的“更深刻”的原因在于害怕失去决策自主权（autonomy）。文中明确指出，一旦人们被告知自己的偏好可被预测，他们会故意选择不符合偏好的选项，以“重申独立性”。因此，选项 C“剥夺他们的决策自主权”是根本原因。文中虽提及 AI 的技术失误（如 45 秒加鸡蛋），但那并非消费者犹豫的主要原因，故 D 不准确。A 和 B 文中未作为主要原因提及。

2. A

解析：作者在文章倒数第四段以“送礼”为例，是为了说明购物具有情感和人际价值。该段指出，选礼物需要揣摩对方喜好、付出努力，这个过程本身蕴含关怀与心意；若被 AI 代劳，礼物就变成了单纯的“投递”，失去了情感联结。这印证了选项 A。其他选项与送礼举例的目的无关。

3. B

解析：作者对 AI 购物助手的总体态度是谨慎关切。文章既承认 AI 能带来扫描商品、比价等“巨大便利”，但更着重分析了其可能造成的“情感风险”，如消解期待喜悦、侵蚀个人伦理表达和社交互动，并呼吁立法防止公司唯利是图。这种既看到好处又强烈担忧潜在人文代价的基调，属于“谨慎关切”，而非盲目乐观、全盘否定或强力支持。

4. B

解析：最适合的标题是《AI 辅助购物背后隐藏的人类代价》。全文主旨并非预言 AI 将彻底替代人类（A），也不是单纯描述零售技术革命（C）或公司如何利用焦虑获利（D），而是系统性地揭示自动化购物如何在效率外衣下，让人们在心理（期待之乐）、伦理（自主选择与价值表达）和社交（共同逛店、送礼心意）等层面悄然付出代价。这与原文标题“What we lose when AI does our shopping”一脉相承。

二、长难句解析

1. Our research finds that without updated legal measures, this shift toward automated commerce could quietly erode the economic, psychological and social benefits that people receive from shopping on their own terms.

- a) **主干识别：**主句为“Our research finds that...”，宾语从句的主干是“this shift... could quietly erode... the benefits”。
- b) **语法拆解：**介词短语“without updated legal measures”作条件状语，修饰从句谓语；“that people receive...”为定语从句，修饰“benefits”；“on one's own terms”是固定短语，意为“按照自己的方式”。
- c) **参考译文：**我们的研究发现，如果没有与时俱进的法律措施，这种朝自动化商业的转向可能会悄然侵蚀人们从自主购物中获得的经济、心理及社交益处。
- d) **解题技巧：**考研翻译中，遇到宾语从句内含较长的状语时，可先将状语提前翻译，再梳理主干。定语从句较短时，可采用前置法译为“……的”。

2. In one study involving people booking travel plans, participants deliberately chose trip options that were misaligned with their stated preferences once they were told their choices could be predicted — a way of reasserting independence.

- a) **主干识别：**句子主干为“participants deliberately chose trip options”。
- b) **语法拆解：**句首“In one study...”是状语，其中“involving...”为现在分词短语作后置定语修饰“study”；“that were misaligned...”是定语从句修饰“options”；“once they were told...”是时间状语从句；破折号后“a way of reasserting independence”是同位语，概括整件事的性质。
- c) **参考译文：**在一项涉及人们预订旅行计划的研究中，当参与者被告知自己的选择可以被预测后，他们反而故意选择与自身明确偏好不符的旅行方案——这成了他们重申自主性的一种方式。
- d) **解题技巧：**处理复杂定语时，若“介词+分词”结构较长，可单独译为短句。破折号后的同位语常表示总结或补充，翻译时可用“这（即）……”来衔接。

3. Perhaps the least-settled, yet most crucial question is whether AI shopping tools will be designed and regulated to serve users' interests and human flourishing — or optimized, as so many digital tools before them, primarily for corporate profit.

- a) **主干识别：**主句为主系表结构“the... question is whether...”，表语从句由“whether... or...”连接两个并列谓语。
- b) **语法拆解：**表语从句中，“will be designed and regulated... or (will be) optimized...”省略了助动词；“as so many digital tools before them”是比较状语从句的省略形式，完整为“as so many digital tools before them were optimized”。

- c) **参考译文：**或许最悬而未决、却也最关键的问题是：人工智能购物工具的设计与监管，究竟是要服务于用户利益与人类繁荣，还是会像此前众多数字工具一样，被优化得主要为公司利润服务。
- d) **解题技巧：**考研长难句中“as”引导的比较省略结构极为常见，理解时务必补出省略的谓语，抓住对比逻辑，避免误译。

三、重点词汇解析

1. remarkable *a.* 非凡的，显著的（文中指“大量的”）

同义：notable, striking | 反义：ordinary, unremarkable

真题例句：It is a remarkable achievement. (2014 Text 2)

词根：mark (标记) + -able → 值得标记的 → 非凡的

2. shift *n.* 转变，转移（文中指购物方式“正在急剧转变”）

同义：switch, change | 反义：stagnation

真题例句：...a major shift in perspective. (2010 Text 3)

搭配：shift from... to...

3. automate *v.* 使自动化

同义：mechanize, robotize

词根：auto- (自己) + mat (动) → 自动运行

派生：automation (*n.*), automatic (*a.*)

4. agent *n.* 代理人，代理商；文中指“AI 代理”

同义：representative, broker

真题例句：...as an agent of the state. (2018 完形)

词根：ag- (做) + -ent (人) → 做事的人 → 代理人

5. autonomous *a.* 自治的；自主的

同义：independent, self-governing | 反义：dependent

真题例句：They became more autonomous. (2009 Text 4)

词根：auto- (自己) + nom (法则) + -ous → 自己定法的 → 自治的

6. perceive *v.* 察觉，认为

同义：notice, sense | 反义：overlook

真题例句：...perceive the sensitivity of personal data. (2003 Text 3)

词根：per- (完全) + ceive (抓) → 完全抓住 → 感知

7. steer *v.* 引导，驾驶；文中指“引导消费者的选择”

同义：guide, direct

真题例句：...to steer away from the rocks. (2012 Text 1)

搭配：steer clear of 避开

8. conversion *n.* 转化, 转变; 文中指“转化率”

同义: transformation, switch

真题例句: ...the conversion rate of email... (2013 完形)

词根: *con-* (一起) + *vers* (转) + *-ion* → 转过来 → 转化

9. transparency *n.* 透明 (度), 公开

同义: clarity, openness | 反义: opacity

真题例句: ...transparency and accountability. (2014 Text 4)

词根: *trans-* (穿过) + *par* (出现) + *-ency* → 透过去显现 → 透明

10. implement *v.* 实施, 执行

同义: execute, enforce | 反义: abolish

真题例句: ...to implement the plan. (2010 Text 2)

词根: *im-* (进入) + *ple* (填充) → 填入 → 履行

11. optimize *v.* 优化, 充分利用

同义: enhance, improve

真题例句: ...optimize the use of resources. (2011 Text 3)

词根: *opt-* (最佳) + *-ize* (使动) → 使最佳

12. anticipate *v.* 预期, 期望

同义: expect, foresee

真题例句: ...anticipate the demand. (2005 Text 1)

词根: *anti-* (前) + *cip* (拿) → 提前拿住 → 预料

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Artificial intelligence agents can already search for products, recommend options and even complete purchases on a consumer's behalf. Yet many shoppers remain uneasy about handing over control. Although many consumers report using some AI assistance, most currently say they wouldn't want an AI agent to autonomously complete a shopping transaction, according to a recent survey from the consultancy firm Bain & Company.

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美国人购物方式正在被 AI 重塑，但法律和情感风险不容忽视

美国人花在购物上的时间多得惊人——超过了教育、志愿服务，甚至打电话的时间。但随着各大平台和零售商竞相将商业决策自动化，他们的购物方式正在发生巨变。

人工智能代理已经能够替消费者搜索产品、推荐选项，甚至完成购买。然而，许多购物者对交出控制权仍感不安。咨询公司贝恩的最新调查显示，尽管不少消费者称会使用一些 AI 辅助功能，但目前大多数人表示，不愿让 AI 代理自主完成交易。

作为研究法律与科技交叉领域的学者，我们目睹了 AI 辅助商业的迅速扩张。我们的研究发现，如果不更新法律措施，这种向自动化商业的转变，可能会悄然侵蚀人们自主购物所获得的经济、心理和社会收益。

购者自慎

购物者的犹豫部分源于隐私问题。许多人不愿与 AI 平台分享敏感的个人或财务信息。但更深层的是，人们希望对自己的购物选择有掌控感。当用户无法理解 AI 推荐产品背后的逻辑时，他们的信任度和满意度就会下降。



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Other experiments confirm that the more customers perceive their shopping choices being taken away from them, the more reluctant they are to accept AI purchasing assistance.

Although the technology is expected to get better, there have been some well-publicized missteps reported in financial and tech media. The Wall Street Journal wrote about an AI-powered vending machine that lost money and stocked itself with a live fish. The tech publication Wired cataloged design flaws, like an AI agent taking a full 45 seconds to add eggs to a customer's shopping cart.

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购物者也不愿放弃自主权。在一项涉及预订旅行计划的研究中，当参与者被告知自己的选择可以被预测后，他们故意选择了与自身明确偏好不符的行程——以此作为一种重申独立的方式。

其他实验也证实，顾客越是感觉自己的购物选择权被剥夺，就越不愿意接受 AI 购物辅助。

尽管技术预计会不断改进，但财经和科技媒体已报道过一些广为人知的失误。《华尔街日报》写过一台 AI 自动售货机，不仅亏了钱，还给自己进了一条活鱼。科技媒体《连线》也盘点过设计缺陷，比如一个 AI 代理花了整整 45 秒才把鸡蛋加入顾客的购物车。

AI 购物的商业逻辑

消费者的谨慎是有充分理由的。AI 代理不仅被设计来提供帮助，更被设计来施加影响。研究表明，这些系统能够塑造偏好、引导选择、增加消费，甚至降低消费者退货的可能性。

And companies are hyping these capabilities. The business platform Salesforce promotes AI agents that can “effortlessly upsell,” while payments giant Mastercard reports that its AI assistant, Shopping Muse, generates 15% to 20% higher conversion rates than traditional search — that is, pushing shoppers from browsing to completing a purchase.

For companies, the appeal is obvious. From Amazon’s Rufus app and Walmart’s customer support to AI-enabled grocery carts, companies are rapidly integrating these tools into the shopping experience.

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For example, they can scan numerous products in seconds, compare prices across sellers, track discounts over time, sift through thousands of product reviews, and tailor recommendations to the user’s preferences and needs. They can even read through terms of service and privacy policies, helping consumers detect unfavorable fine print.

But there’s more at stake than these considerations.

企业正在大肆宣传这些功能。商业平台 Salesforce 推广的 AI 代理能“毫不费力地进行追加销售”，而支付巨头万事达卡报告称，其 AI 助手 Shopping Muse 的转化率（即推动购物者从浏览到完成购买）比传统搜索高出 15%至 20%。

对商家而言，吸引力显而易见。从亚马逊的 Rufus 应用、沃尔玛的客服支持，到 AI 购物车，企业正迅速将这些工具融入购物体验。

名为 Sparky 和 Ralph 的助手正被宣传为零售业的未来，技术专家也在呼吁企业为“代理式 AI 购物时代”的品牌建设做好准备。

真正令人担忧的，不是这些系统可能会失败，而是它们可能做得太过成功。

购物中的人性面

AI 购物代理确实带来了可观的好处。

例如，它们能在几秒内扫描海量产品，跨平台比价，追踪历史折扣，筛选数千条评论，并根据用户偏好和需求进行个性化推荐。它们甚至能阅读服务条款和隐私政策，帮消费者发现不利的细则。

但比这些更重要的东西正面临风险。

While consumers have reason to focus on privacy and control, AI shopping agents carry some overlooked emotional risks, such as squashing the joy of anticipation. Psychologists have shown that the period between choosing a purchase and receiving it generates substantial happiness — sometimes more than the product or experience itself. We daydream about the vacation we booked, the outfit we ordered, the meal we planned. Automated buying threatens to drain this anticipatory pleasure.

This anticipation connects to another value: a sense of personal and ethical authorship. Even mundane shopping decisions allow people to exercise choice and express judgment. Many consumers deliberately buy fair-trade coffee, cruelty-free cosmetics or environmentally responsible products. The brands and products we choose, from Patagonia and Harley-Davidson to a Taylor Swift tour shirt, help shape who we are.

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The same is true of gift-giving. Choosing a gift involves anticipating another person's preferences, investing effort in the search and recognizing that the gesture matters as much as the object itself. When this process is outsourced to an autonomous system, the gift risks becoming a delivery rather than a meaningful gesture of attention and care.

除了消费者有理由关注隐私和控制权外，AI 购物代理还带来了一些被忽视的情感风险，比如扼杀期待的乐趣。心理学家已证明，从选定商品到收货的这段时间，会产生巨大的幸福感——有时甚至超过产品体验本身。我们会遐想已预订的假期、下单的服装、计划的晚餐。而自动化购买，可能会耗尽这种预期的快乐。

这种期待感与另一种价值相连：个人和道德上的“作者感”。即便是日常的购物决策，也让人得以行使选择权、表达判断力。许多消费者会特意购买公平贸易咖啡、零残忍化妆品或环保产品。我们选择的品牌和产品——从巴塔哥尼亚、哈雷戴维森，到泰勒·斯威夫特的巡演 T 恤——都参与塑造了我们的身份。

此外，购物还具有社交维度。我们会和朋友一起逛店，和店员聊天，为我们所爱的人挑选东西。这些日常互动对我们的幸福感贡献巨大。

送礼也是同样的道理。挑选礼物需要预判对方的喜好，在搜寻中投入心力，并明白心意本身与礼物同等重要。当这个过程被外包给自动化系统时，礼物就有沦为一次“配送”的风险，而非一种体现关注与关爱的有意义之举。

Keeping human agency alive

AI shopping agents are likely to become part of everyday life, and the regulatory conversation is beginning to catch up, albeit unevenly.

Transparency has emerged as a central concern. Past experience with recommendation engines shows that undisclosed conflicts of interest are a real risk. The European Union has proposed a disclosure framework around automated decision-making, although its implementation was recently delayed. In Congress, U.S. lawmakers are considering bills to require companies to reveal how their AI models were trained.

So far, consumers seem to want to choose their own level of engagement — a signal that shopping, for many people, is more than just the efficient satisfaction of preferences. Perhaps the least-settled, yet most crucial question is whether AI shopping tools will be designed and regulated to serve users' interests and human flourishing — or optimized, as so many digital tools before them, primarily for corporate profit.

保持人的自主性

AI 购物代理很可能成为日常生活的一部分，而监管层面的讨论正开始跟上，尽管步调不一。

透明度已成为核心关切。推荐引擎的过往经验表明，未披露的利益冲突是真实存在的风险。欧盟已提出一个围绕自动化决策的披露框架，尽管实施时间最近被推迟。在美国国会，立法者正考虑要求企业披露其 AI 模型训练方式的法案。

就目前看，消费者似乎希望自行选择参与程度——这传递出一个信号：对许多人而言，购物不仅仅是偏好的高效满足。或许，最悬而未决却又至关重要的问题是：AI 购物工具的设计与监管，究竟会服务于用户的利益与人的全面发展，还是会像之前众多数字工具一样，首要为企业的利润而优化？